See how an argument fits together

Identify the reasons, conclusion, and background, then show what supports what.

Suggested teaching time: 20 min | Preparation: about 5 min

Introductory | Secondary and adult learners | Individual writing, pairs, and class discussion

Prerequisites: None

Students will be able to

- Distinguish the conclusion from its supporting reasons and background.
- Show the direction of support using an arrow or a written explanation.
- Explain why a true detail need not be a reason for this conclusion.

Prepare and gather

- One student handout per learner, or display the activities and use paper.
- Pens or pencils; no student devices required.
- Keep the instructor guide and model answers separate from student materials.
- Read the three scenarios and their model answers.
- Print the student handout or display one activity at a time.
- Explain that all scenarios are invented and students should use only the supplied facts.

Teaching sequence

4 min	**Find two supporting reasons.** Read the gallery warm-up. Learners mark the two reasons and the conclusion, then compare arrows with a partner.
7 min	**Map the fundraising argument.** Learners label the main activity and draw its support arrow. Ask why the meeting day is background.
4 min	**Discuss sentence roles.** Reveal the model answer. Use the prompts to distinguish a statement's position from its role.
5 min	**Transfer the skill.** Learners complete the picnic exit ticket independently. Check their labels, arrow, and explanation before sharing the answer.

Timings are suggested starting points, not measured classroom completion times.

Warm-up / The closed gallery

Student task and instructor answer

Explain these words as needed

Conclusion: The statement the argument gives reasons to accept.

Reason: A statement offered in support of the conclusion.

Background: Context that helps describe the situation without being offered as support.

Scenario

Invented scenario: A visitor says, 'The gallery is closed every Monday. Today is Monday. Therefore, the gallery is closed today.'

Student output: Write the conclusion and the two reasons. Show how the reasons support the conclusion.

1. Copy the statement being supported.

2. Copy both supporting statements.

3. Draw arrows from the two reasons to the conclusion, or write how the reasons work together.

Student success check: Do both reasons lead toward the statement about today, rather than away from it?

Model answer

Conclusion: the gallery is closed today. Reasons: it is closed every Monday, and today is Monday. The two reasons work together: today belongs to the set of days when the gallery is closed.

Why this meets the task: It names all three roles and shows how the rule and the fact about today jointly support the conclusion.

Main activity / Compare two fundraisers

Student task and instructor answer

Scenario

Invented scenario: A club member writes: 'Our club meets on Tuesdays. Last month's bake sale earned $300 after costs, while the car wash earned $180. Therefore, we should hold another bake sale next month.'

Student output: Label the three sentences, draw one support arrow, and write one explanatory sentence.

1. Label each sentence background, reason, or conclusion.
2. Draw an arrow from the reason to the conclusion, or write 'reason -> conclusion' using the actual sentences.
3. Explain in one sentence why the Tuesday meeting detail is not support for the fundraising recommendation.

Student success check: Does your arrow show which statement supports which? The most detailed sentence need not be the conclusion.

Model answer

Tuesday meetings are background. The $300 versus $180 earnings comparison is the reason. Holding another bake sale is the conclusion. Draw the arrow from the earnings comparison to the recommendation. Meeting on Tuesday supplies no comparison of the two fundraising options.

Why this meets the task: The answer maps the argument's structure and explains why a true detail is not necessarily a reason.

Exit ticket / The picnic plan

Student task and instructor answer

Scenario

Invented scenario: A club member writes, 'Our club was founded in 2018. The forecast predicts heavy rain during tomorrow's picnic. We should move tomorrow's picnic indoors.'

Student output: Label the three sentences and show the support relation; explain one label.

1. Label each sentence background, reason, or conclusion.

2. Draw an arrow from the supporting sentence to the conclusion, or write the relation in words.

3. Explain why the founding year does not support the proposed move.

Student success check: Have you identified what supports the recommendation without treating the weather forecast as a guarantee?

Model answer

Background: the club was founded in 2018. Reason: heavy rain is forecast during the picnic. Conclusion: move tomorrow's picnic indoors. The forecast supports the proposed move; the founding year says nothing about tomorrow's weather or location.

Why this meets the task: The answer maps the argument without claiming that the forecast guarantees rain or that no other considerations matter.

Check understanding

Mark each criterion met or needs another attempt. Accept equivalent wording; assess the reasoning, not a memorized phrase.

- The conclusion and reason are correctly identified.

- The arrow or explanation shows support flowing from reason to conclusion.

- Background is distinguished by its lack of a supporting connection to this recommendation.

Discussion and adaptations

Use the supplied guidance to keep the lesson focused on its reasoning skill.

Discussion prompts

Must the conclusion be the last sentence?

Listen for: No. An argument can begin with its conclusion. Identify which statement the others support, rather than relying on sentence order.

Does finding a reason show that it is a good reason?

Listen for: No. Mapping identifies its intended role. Evaluating its accuracy, relevance, or strength is a further task.

Common confusions

The most detailed sentence is the conclusion. Detail does not decide the role. In the fundraiser, the detailed earnings comparison supports the recommendation.

A true background fact must support the conclusion. Truth and a supporting connection are different. The meeting day can be true without favoring either fundraiser.

Every argument has exactly one reason. The gallery example needs two reasons working together. Other arguments can have more.

Adapt the lesson

More support: Supply the three role labels and let learners arrange them beside each sentence. Ask them to complete: "This reason supports this conclusion because..."

More challenge: Ask learners to put the fundraiser conclusion first while preserving its reason. Expected answer: "We should hold another bake sale because it earned $300 after costs, compared with $180 for the car wash." The order changes; the support relation does not.

Next practice

https://xixteen.com/learners/?practice=find_argument#workbench